# Kingdom Come: Deliverance II Level Analysis: "For Whom the Bell Tolls"

## Analysis of Spatial Narrative & Diegetic Pressure Mechanics

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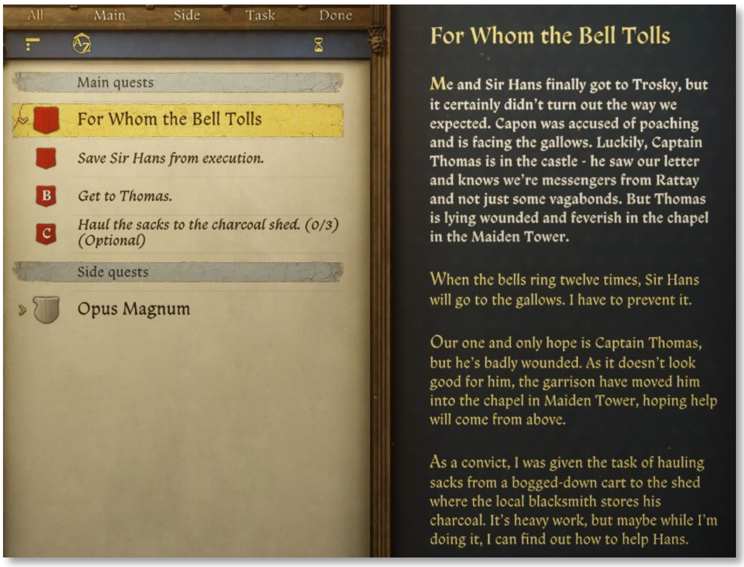
# I. Level Overview: Goals, Context, & Core Experience




### 1. Basic Information

**Mission Name:** For Whom the Bell Tolls

**Location:** Trosky Castle

**Level Type:** Closed Sandbox / Immersive Sim / Timed Infiltration

**Core Mechanic:** Diegetic Audio Timer / Dynamic Clearance System based on Progression

### 2. Narrative Context

The protagonist, Henry, and Sir Hans are detained after losing their noble credentials during a bandit ambush and being accused of poaching. To prevent their imminent execution, players must locate the only ally within the castle who can verify our identity: Captain Thomas. However, Thomas is critically wounded and quarantined in the highest tower, "the Maiden." The level structures a progression path from the bottom (prisoner/laborer) to the top (military restricted zone), representing a shift in class and access.

### 3. Objective Breakdown

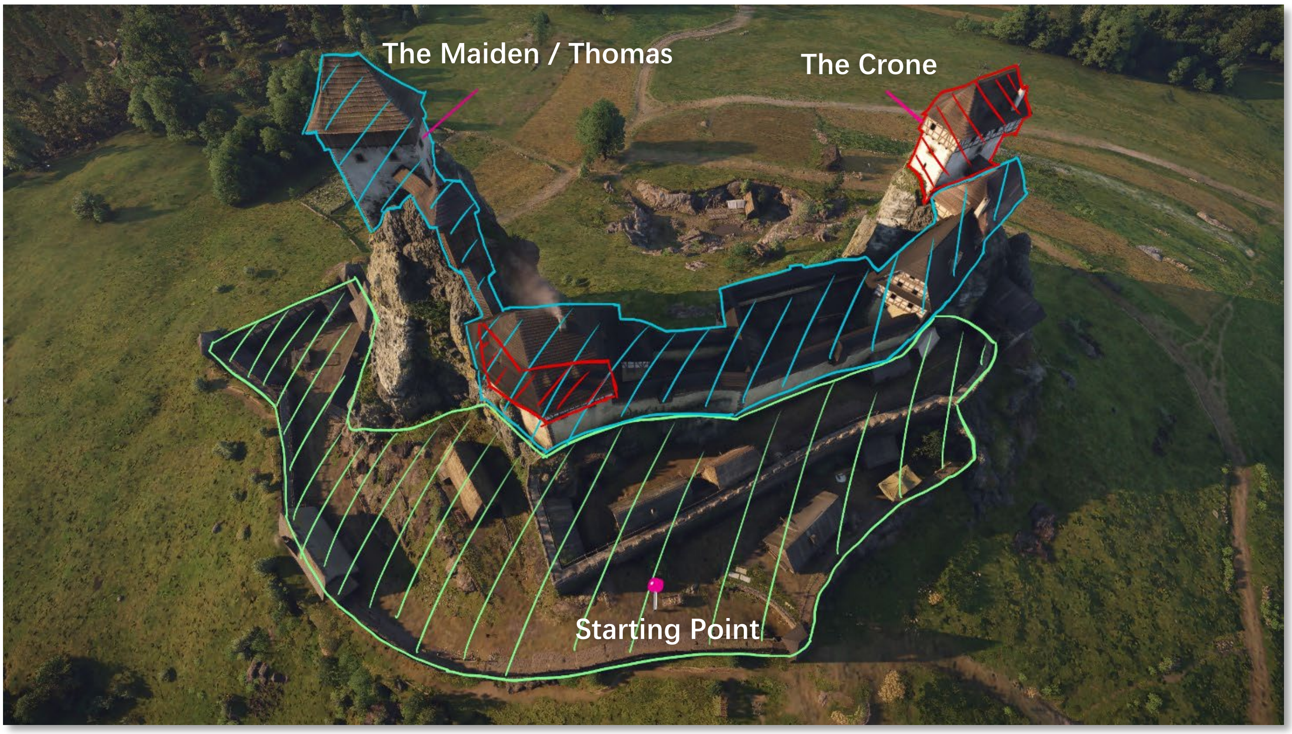
- **Victory Condition:** Secure Captain Thomas in the top of the Maiden tower.
- **Failure Condition:** The 12th Bell rings (Execution begins).
- **Optional Objectives:** Complete labor tasks (Move Sacks), Side quests (Blacksmithing/Play Dice/Fix Axe/Help Chamberlain/etc. ).
- **Pathways to Victory (Implicit Intent):** The level provides distinct pathways to achieve the Victory Condition, balancing "Legitimate Access" against "Time Consumption":
  - *High Trust / Low Risk:* Gaining clearance through labor (moving sacks, smithing, kitchen aid) is safe but heavily taxes the Time Budget.
  - *Low Trust / High Risk:* Stealth, using the well, or brute force saves time but introduces high combat risk.

### 4. Core Experience Pillars

- **High Player Agency:** The mission supports multiple solutions. Players can choose to complete or skip various sub-tasks and utilize tools, allowing for non-linear progression.
- **Diegetic Pressure Mechanics:** Abandoning the traditional UI countdown, the level uses environmental audio (Bells) as the sole time indicator. This forces players to maintain auditory awareness, creating psychological urgency that discourages perfectionism and forces sub-optimal decision making.

- **Dynamic Clearance System:** Player’s status is not static. Initially, as a laborer, the player has clearance in the outer perimeter. The Inner Courtyard is a "Trespassing/Expelling" zone, and tower interiors are "Hostile" zones. Side quests serve as the mechanism to upgrade clearance status dynamically.

## II. Spatial Structure & Zoning




### 1. Spatial Logic: The Funnel Design

The level's spatial experience is not a flat maze, but a distinct funnel structure. The player's movement flow starts from the wide Outer Courtyard, constricts into narrow connecting passages, and finally squeezes into the claustrophobic Tower interiors. This spatial compression, combined with the level progression, naturally escalates tension:

**Outer Perimeter:** Open sightlines, sparse cover, but allows for free movement.

**Core:** Narrow sightlines, numerous blind spots (ideal for breaking line of sight), but detection results in Expel (Blue Zone) or Combat (Red Zone).

### 2. Zoning Hierarchy & Awareness Systems

Based on the detection system, I identified three distinct zones that dictate the gameplay rhythm:

Green Zone: Public Area

**Scope:** Outer walls, Charcoal shed, Well entrance.

**Mechanic:** White-list zone. As long as the player does not commit theft or violence, they are completely safe. This serves as the initial staging area for observation, route planning, and completing prerequisite tasks (e.g., labor).

**Feature:** Provides a low-pressure environment and information gathering points (Quest NPCs).


Blue Zone: Trespassing / Buffer Zone

**Scope:** Inner Courtyard, connecting corridors, stairs.

**Mechanic:** Soft Gate. If entered without clearance, AI initiates warnings and attempts to escort the player out rather than engaging in immediate combat.

**Feature:** Forgiveness Buffer. It allows the player to explore, make navigation errors, or attempt stealth without harsh punishment. However, AI will shadow the player, and prolonged non-compliance triggers an arrest state.

Red Zone: Hostile / Restricted Area

**Scope:** The Crone (the Alchemy room), The Maiden (the Private rooms only).

**Mechanic:** Hard Gate. Any Line of Sight (LoS) contact triggers immediate Arrest or Combat.

**Feature:** Tight indoor environments with no long-distance escape routes. Forces the player to strictly manage LoS or utilize stealth takedowns.


### 3. AI Archetypes & Behavior Logic

To understand the stealth gameplay, I analyzed the AI logic deployed in different zones:

- **Type A: Active Guards**
  - **Behavior:** Patrols fixed routes, actively scans for intruders.
  - **Logic:** In the Blue Zone, they trigger the "Escort/Expel" state upon detection. They serve as dynamic obstacles that force players to time their movements.
- **Type B: Static Guards**
  - **Behavior:** Stationary, often guarding doors, specific rooms, or important pathways.
  - **Logic:** Mostly found in the Red Zone (Tower interiors). In this level, they are often positioned facing *away* from the player, reducing the challenge to simple "backstab" checks rather than complex navigation puzzles.
- **Type C: The Civilian (Alarm)**

- **Behavior:** Flees and reports upon seeing crimes.
- **Logic:** Acts as a mobile alarm trigger, extra obstacles when players try to commit crime.

**3. Key Locations**

📍 **Start Point:** The initial location where the protagonist enters the mission after captured.

**The Crone (Critical Dependency):**

- **Function:** Acts as a mandatory logical blocker before the Victory Condition. The player must visit this tower to acquire the Key Item: Fever Tonic, which is exclusively located here, either crafted at the Alchemy Bench (Top Floor) or stolen from the Scribe's chest (2nd Floor).

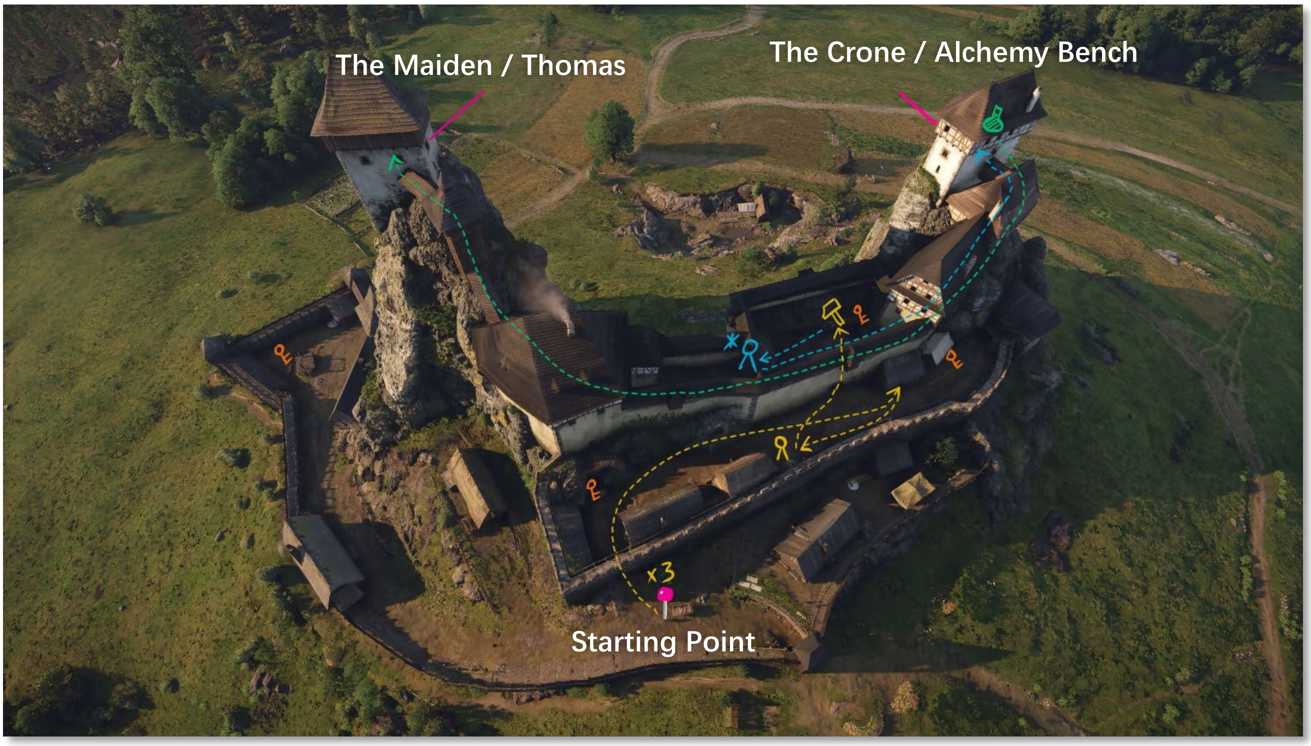
**The Maiden (Victory Node):**

- **Function:** The final destination containing Captain Thomas.
- **Blocking Logic:** Interaction with Thomas to complete the mission is conditional. The Player can visit it early but cannot complete mission without the Fever Tonic from the Crone.

## III. Flow & Path Analysis

**Multi-dimensional Problem Solving:** The level adopts a classic **Immersive Sim** design philosophy, offering at least three distinct and logical paths. These paths and design elements are not mutually exclusive: Players can mix and match solutions based on their character build (Speech/Stats/Stealth), player skill (Lockpicking/Combat), or understanding of the game mechanics (Systemic Knowledge).

**1. Path A: The Standard (Lawful) Route**




**Core Logic:** Trading Time for Safety.

**Flow Description:** The player follows guard instructions: 1. Complete repetitive labor (moving sacks x3); 2. Obtain a smithing job in the Inner Courtyard from the blacksmith, expanding lawful access; 3.

Acquire a lockpick set from various side quests; 4. Pass a Skill Check with the chamberlain to gain access to the Alchemy bench in the Crone; 5. Use the lockpick to access ingredients and craft the Fever Tonic at the Alchemy bench; 6. Deliver the tonic to Thomas in the Maiden.

**Experience Analysis:**

**Pros:** Lowest risk, minimal combat pressure, offers the most complete narrative experience.

**Cons:** Lengthy process with high action density. Requires frequent engagement in mini-games (Smithing, Dice, Grinding) and traversing the map. Although the actual time cost is controlled (approx. 2 Bell Cycles), the tedious labor induces psychological fatigue for the player.

**Design Intent:** As the standard route, it ensures players with lower mechanical skills or peaceful playstyles can complete the mission. The monotonous labor is intentionally designed to contrast with and heighten the satisfaction of the eventual success.

**2. Path B: The Spatial Shortcut**

**Core Logic:** Trading Risk for Time.

**Flow Description:** Utilizing the well in the outer perimeter as a hidden entrance. The player sacrifices health (fall damage) to bypass the Inner Courtyard gate guards via the sewers, entering the Maiden directly. However, the player must still acquire the Fever Tonic through other means.

**Experience Analysis:**

**Pros:** A topological shortcut that shortens the mission loop, rewarding observant players.

**Cons:** Still requires obtaining the Fever Tonic separately. Furthermore, bypassing the legitimate clearance process forces full stealth, which paradoxically consumes more time.

**Design Intent:** Sacrificing Health (HP) to skip parts of the quest flow.

**3. Path C: Fast-tracking the Fever Tonic**



**Core Logic:** Fast-tracking the Critical Item through committing crime.

**Flow Description:** In the Scribe's room at the top of **the Crone**, steal the key or knock out the Scribe to open the chest next to him, which contains a static spawn of the **Fever Tonic**.

**Experience Analysis:**

**Pros:** Skips all lockpick acquisition quests, lockpicking mini-games, and alchemy crafting. Directly acquires the Key Item.

**Cons:** Requires stealth and crime. Demands prior knowledge that the tonic is in the chest (no UI prompt) or methodical room-by-room looting until the Scribe's room is searched.

**Design Intent:** The item is placed in the world persistently, not triggered by dialogue. Rewards thorough exploration and provides a shortcut for replayability/meta-gaming.

**4. Unconventional Path D: Speedrun (Meta-Game)**

**Core Logic:** Exploiting the **"Buffer"** mechanics of the "Expel" state.

**Flow Description:** Without any clearance, the player sprints into the Inner Courtyard and up the Crone. Due to high movement speed, the player breaks the AI's detection/escort range before the "Expelling" state escalates to "Combat." After grabbing the tonic from the Scribe, the player sprints again to the Maiden to complete the objective.

**Experience Analysis:**

**Pros:** Mission completion in under 2 minutes. Requires zero stealth or skill point checks.

**Cons:** Skips all content and rewards. Breaks narrative immersion. Requires extensive map knowledge (Meta-knowledge).

**Design Intent:** Likely an emergent result of system mechanics rather than explicit design. While it breaks immersion, it significantly enhances replay value as a systemic exploit.

**5. Unconventional Path E: Brute Force**

**Core Logic: Eliminating all threats to clear the map.**

**Flow Description:** Stealth kill a guard to acquire gear, then engage in combat intentionally. Eliminate all reinforcements. Once all hostiles are dead, retrieve the tonic and deliver it to Thomas.

**Experience Analysis:**

**Pros:** Pure combat satisfaction. No quest requirements.

**Cons:** Extremely high difficulty. Reputation drops to minimum, causing long-term negative consequences.

**Design Intent:** Preserves the possibility of a violent solution, ensuring the game simulates a consistent world rather than forcing a specific playstyle.

**Path Comparison Matrix:**

| **Path Type** | **Core Content** | **Risk Level** | **Time Cost** | **Player Requirement** |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **0.Direct Stealth** | First-time / No Quests | ⭐⭐⭐⭐ | ⭐⭐⭐⭐ | Stealth Mechanics |
| **A.Dialogue/Lawful** | Dialogue / Checks | ⭐ | ⭐⭐⭐ | Patience, Compliance |
| **B.Stealth/Shortcut** | Spatial Shortcut | ⭐⭐⭐ | ⭐⭐⭐ | Observation, Stealth Mechanics |

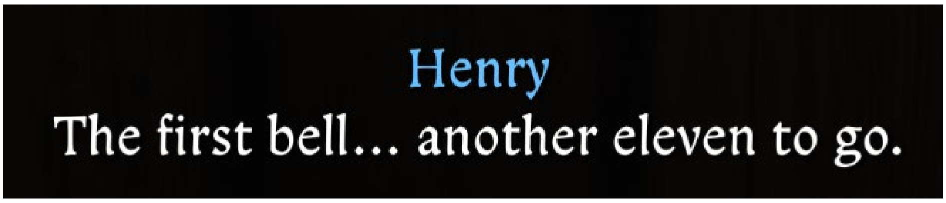
| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **C.Stealth/Shortcut** | Item Shortcut | ⭐⭐ | ⭐⭐ | Map Exploration, Looting |
| **D.Speedrun** | Meta-Knowledge | ⭐⭐ | ⭐ | System Understanding / Map Memorization |
| **E.Combat** | Combat Skill | ⭐⭐⭐⭐⭐ | ⭐⭐⭐⭐⭐ | Combat Proficiency |

**Conclusion: By offering these varied paths, the level perfectly covers the needs of Explorers, Achievers, and Killers (Bartle Taxonomy).**

## IV. Core Mechanic Analysis: Auditory Pressure & Time Economy

**1. Mechanism Breakdown:** The Diegetic Immersive Timer

The level abandons the traditional UI countdown, utilizing Environmental Audio (Bells) and Protagonist Narrative Feedback to construct time perception.




*The mission has a fixed limit of 12 bells. Every time a bell rings, the player character triggers a monologue.*

**Double Layer Feedback:** The bells serve as a global notification on the physical layer, while Henry's anxious lines (e.g., "Damn, that's the sixth bell") apply pressure on the emotional layer.

**Blurred Boundaries:** The player cannot know exactly "how many minutes remain," only perceiving that "time is running out." This Information Asymmetry is the key to manufacturing stress.

**2. Data Verification: Time Tolerance & Consumption Test**

To verify the level's numerical balance, I conducted an efficiency stress test on **Route A (Lawful Route)**, which has the most steps and highest complexity.

- **Test Environment:** necessary main quest steps only, maximizing lawful area access acquisition.
- **Total Time Budget:** 12 Bell Cycles (Approx. 15 minutes real-time per cycle).

| **Process Phase** | **Key Actions** | **Time Cost (Tested)** | **Bell Progress** |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Phase 1: Identity Acquisition** | Move sacks (x3) →Smithing →Kitchen Lockpicking →**Chamberlain** Check | ~ 15 mins | **1st Bell** |
| **Phase 2: Critical Item** | Go to **the Crone →Alchemy Bench** (Time Acceleration) | ~ 6 mins | **2nd Bell** |
| **Phase 3: Delivery** | Go to **the Maiden** (Top) → Deliver **Fever Tonic** | ~ 2 mins | **Mission Complete** |

### 3. Design Redundancy & Exploration Tolerance

By comparing the **lawful flow** (only 2 bells) against the **total budget** (12 bells), I discovered the designer reserved an **80% Time Buffer**. This does not mean the countdown is fake, but rather based on the following considerations:

- **Mitigating Navigation Friction for First-Time Experience:**
  KCD2's map is complex and lacks heavy-handed guidance (e.g., no glowing path markers). First-time players incur a high onboarding cost, needing significant time to build mental maps, identify NPCs, and read quest text. The time buffer is essentially the necessary time allowance for new players to learn the level.
- **Supporting the Looting Loop & Immersion:**
  As an Immersive Sim, looting, reading books, and stealing non-quest items are core engagement loops. If the time budget were too tight (e.g., only 3 bells), players would be forced to abandon all exploration fun to rush the objective.

**Design Intent:** The bells exist to prevent stalling, not to prohibit normal exploration. The mechanic maintains narrative urgency without sacrificing the core RPG experience of progression and discovery.

**Conclusion:** The level's numerical design creates a compelling gap between Perceived Pressure and Actual Difficulty. The bells create high narrative tension, but the underlying math provides a generous safety buffer. This contrast ensures that immersive players can enjoy the exploration loop, yet still experience a thrilling "last-minute" success without the frustration of a tight timer..

## V. Post-Mortem Analysis & Actionable Feedback

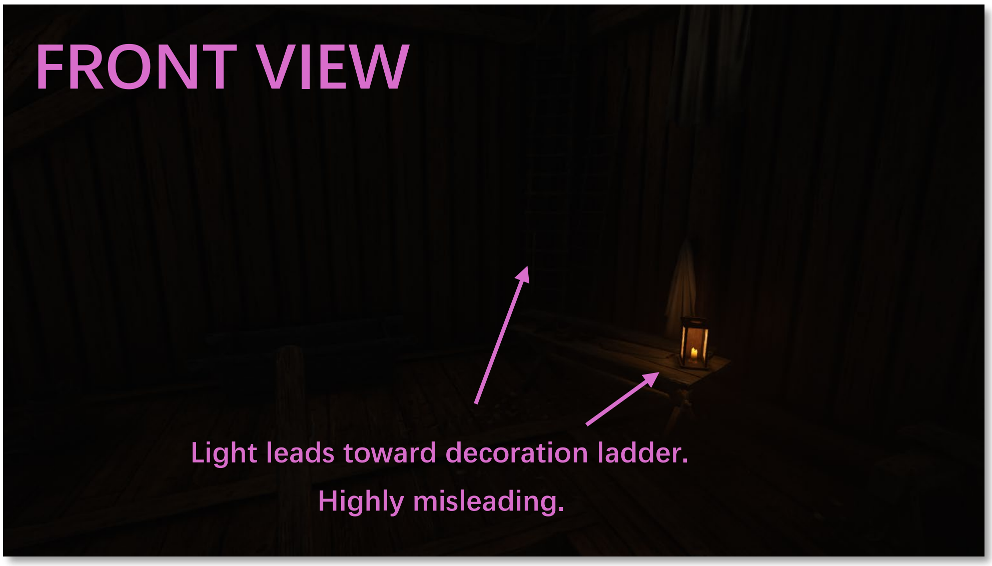
### 1. Design Highlights

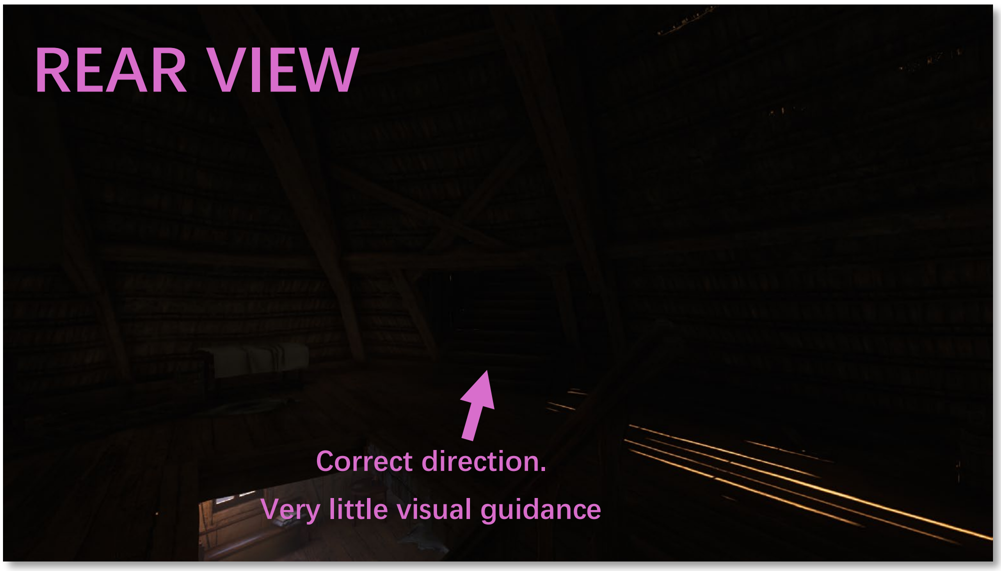
- **Excellence in Immersive Sim:**
  - The level perfectly realizes **Goal-Oriented** rather than **Script-Oriented** design. The multiple paths are logically self-consistent, allowing seamless switching between lawful and criminal playstyles, providing high freedom and replay value.
- **Smart Pressure Threshold Control:**
  - By combining high operational density with the bell countdown, the design successfully manufactures a psychological urgency that fits the narrative, all while maintaining a generous safety buffer (12 bells).

### 1.Critical Issues

- **Issue 1: Inverted Difficulty Curve & Static AI (Pacing Risk)**
  - **Problem:** The level presents a counter-intuitive "Tight Outer, Loose Inner" structure.
    **Outer (Blue Zone):** High guard density, intersecting patrol paths, high stealth challenge.
    **Core (Red Zone):** Once inside the towers, guard count drops sharply. Most are **Static Guards** with their backs turned to the player, making them easy targets for stealth takedowns.
  - **Consequence:** This leads to an anti-climactic experience at the narrative peak (infiltrating the top of the tower). Players can bypass challenges without planning or using tools, diminishing the sense of accomplishment.

- **Issue 2: Misleading Visual Guidance (UX Friction)**




  - **Problem:** In the tower attic areas, the lighting layout violates the principle of Phototropism (attraction to light). High-contrast light sources are placed in non-interactive dead ends, while key navigation nodes (ladders) are hidden in low-light shadows.
  - **Consequence:** Under time pressure, this causes player frustration due to navigation errors. This friction stems from incorrect visual cues rather than intended spatial complexity.
- **Issue 3: Information Gap on Critical Path**
  - **Problem:** The Critical Item for Path C (Fever Tonic) is placed in a locked chest in the Crone without sufficient breadcrumbing. Unless players full search or possess meta-knowledge, logical deduction is insufficient to locate the item.

**3. Improvement Proposals**

- **Fixing Visual Guidance (Lighting Tuning):**
  - **Proposal:** Realign light sources to serve both atmosphere and function.

    - **Action:** Relocate the candles from the dead-end corner to the base of the ladder, or add a window on the adjacent wall to introduce more natural light. This creates a local Highlight to draw the eye without breaking the map's realistic aesthetic.
- **Fixing AI Configuration (Pacing Adjustment):**
    - **Proposal:** Adjust guard density and behavior in the Inner Courtyard and Towers.
    - **Action:** Add 1-2 Patrolling Guards in the stairwells/corridors of the Crone and the Maiden. Reorient static guards in key rooms to face doorways or flank corridors. This forces players to utilize distraction mechanics (throwing stones/whistling) to create blind spots, rather than relying on effortless backstabs.
- **Optimizing Item Guidance (Narrative Clue):**
    - **Proposal: Add specific context clues.**
    - **Action:** During the information gathering phase (e.g., talking to the priest or kitchen maid), add a specific bark/dialogue line. Example: *"The 4DSJCF has been complaining about headaches lately; he took a bottle of my 'FWFS5PODJD up to his room."*